

Four years when Europe's inflation forecasters **all missed together**

Every quarter the ECB asks about fifty banks and research institutes where inflation will land — and how sure they are about it.

In 2022 it came in at **8.4%**. Not one of the fifty had that inside their own range.

So I checked all 26 years.

What the survey actually asks

Not “what is your number”. Each institution submits a full probability distribution: where inflation lands, and how confident they are.

That is what makes this checkable. You can score whether someone was honest about their uncertainty, not just whether their midpoint was close.

64

forecasters with 10+ scored
years

1,184

forecasts scored

26

years followed, one by one

These are outside institutions, not the ECB's own staff projections. The ECB publishes panellists only by number; nothing here identifies any of them.

Four years when Europe's inflation forecasters **all missed together**

Each bar: the share of the ECB's forecaster panel whose own 80% range contained that year's euro-area inflation. 64 forecasters, 2000–2025.

In 2008, and again in 2021, 2022 and 2023: not one of them.

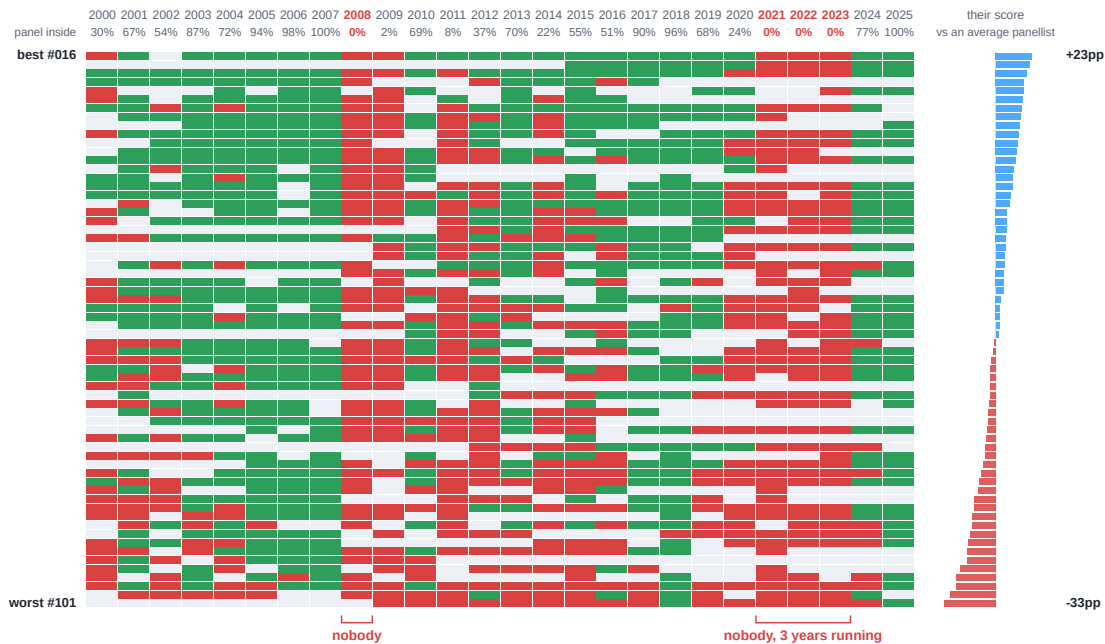


Data: ECB Survey of Professional Forecasters, individual responses, one-year-ahead vs euro-area HICP.
Method and every number: namikakmandev.github.io/ecb-forecaster-skill.html

ECB inflation panel, 2000–2025: green = the outcome landed inside their range

One row per anonymous ECB forecaster (64 of them, sorted best at the top), one column per year. Each said where euro-area inflation would land with 80% confidence. **Green** = it did. **Red** = it did not. Grey = not on the panel that year.

■ inside their range ■ missed ■ not on the panel



The columns are the story: in 2008, and again through 2021–2023, not one of the 64 was inside the range they themselves had published. The rows are the other story: some are green far more often than others — but the best of them still quotes a wider range.

Data: ECB Survey of Professional Forecasters, individual responses, one-year-ahead (Q4 round of the year before) vs euro-area HICP, 10+ scored years each. Forecasters are anonymous; the ECB publishes them only by number. · method and every number: namikakmandev.github.io/ecb-forecaster-skill.html

Read it down the columns

2008, 2021, 2022 and 2023

In each of those years, **not one** forecaster on the panel contained the outcome. The years a range was worth most are the years it carried no information.

And they were all wrong the same way. **178 forecasts across those four years, 178 underestimates, zero overestimates.** When this panel fails completely, it does not see costs coming.

Not a one-way record overall: across all 26 years 65% of misses were too low and 35% too high. It is the total failures that are one-sided.

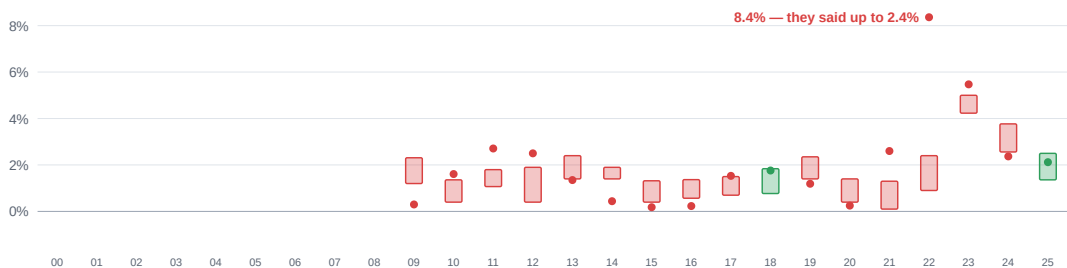
What a miss looks like — ECB panel, euro-area inflation, 2000–2025

Each bar is the range one forecaster published for that year's euro-area inflation — the middle 80% of what they thought possible. The dot is what inflation actually did. Dot inside the bar = **a hit**. Dot outside = **a miss**. A year with no bar is a year they were not on the panel.

Forecaster #016 — the best of the panel: inside its own range 19 years out of 25



Forecaster #101 — the worst of the panel: inside its own range 2 years out of 17



Both were wrong about 2022. The difference is that #016 publishes ranges wide enough to be right the rest of the time.

Data: ECB Survey of Professional Forecasters, individual responses, one-year-ahead (Q4 round of the year before), vs euro-area HICP.
Forecasters are anonymous; the ECB publishes them only by number. · method and every number: namikakmandev.github.io/ecb-forecaster-skill.html

Read it across the rows instead and they are not interchangeable:
best to worst is **57 percentage points**, far too wide to be luck.

But the best forecaster publishes ranges **2.5× wider** than the worst.
Width alone explains **47%** of the score.

Half of looking good here is simply admitting you don't know. Useful
— but not the same as accuracy.

What to do with it

Judge a forecast on two measures, not one:

1. How often the outcome fell inside the stated range.
2. How wide that range had to be to manage it.

Only the second tells you whether they know anything. Where a forecaster is named — a broker, an analyst, a supplier's demand plan — keep both columns yourself.

1 of 64

met the 80% standard they set themselves.

Method, every number and the full script:

namikakmandev.github.io/ecb-forecaster-skill.html

Data: ECB Survey of Professional Forecasters, published openly.